

(depending on the season) for less than I would get 24 nighttime pills at some stores.

4. **Take lots of showers.** I love a good, hot shower, and I've found that timing them well can mean not having to take decongestant. For instance, if I take a hot shower about an hour before bed, the steam loosens the crap in my sinuses and it has time to drain out before I go to bed. Then, I don't have to take the nighttime medicine, which can give me some of the . . . um . . . *strangest* dreams.

5. **Drink mint tea.** Apparently, this won't work if you have gastroesophageal reflux disease (GERD). But if you don't, and you don't hate tea, this is a good way to open up your air passages. I will often drink it when I really need some more decongestant but can't take it because it hasn't been long enough since my last dose or I don't have any on me. It doesn't work for long, but it has gotten me through some hard times. Plus, it tastes good, gives me good breath, and is relaxing.

6. **Use a saline nasal spray.** My sinuses hurt the worst when

they're dry. The saline helps keep them moist, which helps the mucus move through them faster. Once you have a sprayer, you can make your own spray. Otherwise, store brands are cheap and work.

7. **Don't irrigate your sinuses.** Sprays are fine, but shooting salted (or vinegared—yikes!) water through sore, dry sinuses just makes them more sore and more dry after the water dries up. Not to mention, it hurts like the dickens when you do it! They get moist for a short time, but are more irritated in the end.

And when they're full, the water doesn't loosen the mucus much, just makes it a little runnier and more likely to lodge in your ears. I don't know why, but it happens to me every time. I've had the same thing happen when I try to use the steroidal allergy nasal sprays, though.

8. **Try homeopathic remedies.** These are controversial and rightly so, as my experience is that many of them don't work. However, some of them do. And some of them work sometimes, with certain symptoms, and not others. These are usually a pill that dissolves under the tongue or a

